

Two studies, five sessions, one question

What patterns hold across both connector setup flows?

API connector study

March–April · Mid-fi prototype

PARTICIPANTS

3 ATCs

MECHANIC TESTED

Interpret IT-supplied doc, map to UI

HEADLINE FINDING

Labels diverging from doc = stall point

CDC / NetSuite study

May · Low-fi Figma prototype

PARTICIPANTS

2 ATCs (Sr ATC + ATC II)

MECHANIC TESTED

Confirm pre-filled config, choose tier and state

HEADLINE FINDING

Status terminology + tier defaults need work

Why a cross-cutting view now

Different flows, different friction. Patterns that show up in both studies are the strongest design signal we have.

Five patterns that show up in both studies

The high-confidence findings — design against these

Labels are the dominant blocker

Every non-bug stumble across both studies traced to an unfamiliar word with no in-context explanation.

Contextual help is the most-requested feature (5 for 5)

Tooltips, inline blurbs, link-outs, sidebars, before-confirm summaries — same need, different form factors.

Confident-but-wrong defaults are a recurring risk

'Full refresh' for GL data, 'Enhanced' tier without contract check — UI accepts the choice without surfacing implications.

Two-state models are consistently hard for non-technical users

Incremental / full refresh, Pause / Active, Save Only / Save and Set Active — state machines need plain-language gating.

Sample-data previews keep being asked for

Lilith after Test Endpoint, Mallory on Select Tables. Recurring trust signal before users commit to active.

What the CDC study added on top

New themes the API study didn't surface

Dual-audience problem

IT admins and accountants need different things from these screens. One composite flow today.

Open: progressive disclosure or role-segmented flows?

Where this sits in the broader setup journey

Mallory: “Does this replace the existing setup link?”

Intersects onboarding + ATC workflows.

Not a UX-only question.

Refresh-frequency expectation gap

Mallory assumed direct integrations would refresh closer to real time. CDC is hourly (Fivetran).

For PM: customer comms, not a UX or eng change.

Connection-type picker terminology

“Pre-built vs. custom” clashes with the language used in sales/setup (“direct integration”).

Two participants flagged this independently.

Where this leaves us

How the findings sit on our roadmap

High-confidence patterns we're designing against

- Labels-as-failure-mode — every flow, every connector type
- Contextual help is settled as a pattern — design question is what form
- Confident-but-wrong defaults — a class of risk to address systemically

Open design questions we'd value team input on

- What does the consistent contextual-help pattern look like across Data Studio?
- How do we handle the dual-audience question (IT vs. accounting) without forking the flow?

Not ours to solve alone, but worth tracking

- Where Data Studio fits in the broader first-time customer setup journey